

Be Specific

Video Link: [Being Specific](#)

When working with Claude, one of the most effective ways to improve your results is to be specific about what you want. Instead of leaving everything up to the model's interpretation, you can provide clear guidelines or steps that direct Claude toward the kind of output you're looking for.

Think about it this way: if you ask Claude to "write a short story about a character who discovers a hidden talent," Claude could go in countless directions. The story might be 200 words or 2,000 words. It might have one character or five. It could focus on any type of talent discovery scenario.

Be specific

Provide a list of guidelines or steps to direct the model

Not Great

```
prompt = f"""
Write a short story about a
character who discovers a hidden
talent
"""
```



Better!

```
prompt = f"""
Write a short story about a character who
discovers a hidden talent

Guidelines:
1. Keep the story under 1,000 words
2. Include a clear action that reveals the
   character's talent
3. Include at least one supporting
   character
"""
```

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By adding specific guidelines, you give Claude a clearer target to aim for. This dramatically improves both the consistency and quality of the output.

Two Types of Guidelines

There are two main approaches to being specific in your prompts, and you'll often see them used together in professional applications.

Guideline Types

List qualities that the output should have

Write a short story about a character who discovers a hidden talent

Guidelines:

1. Keep the story under 1,000 words
2. Include a clear action that reveals the character's talent
3. Include at least one supporting character

Provide steps the model should follow

Write a short story about a character who discovers a hidden talent

Follow these steps:

1. Brainstorm 3 talents that would create dramatic tension
2. Pick the most interesting talent
3. Outline a pivotal scene that reveals the talent
4. Brainstorm 3 supporting characters types that could increase the impact of this discovery

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Output Quality Guidelines

The first type focuses on listing qualities that your output should have. These guidelines help you control:

- Length of the response
- Structure and format
- Specific attributes or elements to include
- Tone or style requirements

For example, you might specify that a story should be under 1,000 words, include a clear action that reveals the character's talent, and feature at least one supporting character.

Process Steps

The second type provides specific steps for Claude to follow. This approach is particularly useful when you want Claude to think through a problem systematically or consider multiple perspectives before arriving at a final answer.

Instead of jumping straight to writing, you might ask Claude to:

1. Brainstorm three talents that would create dramatic tension
2. Pick the most interesting talent
3. Outline a pivotal scene that reveals the talent
4. Brainstorm supporting character types that could increase the impact

Real-World Impact

The difference that specificity makes is dramatic. In testing a meal planning prompt, adding guidelines improved the evaluation score from 3.92 to 7.86 - more than doubling the quality of the output simply by telling Claude exactly what elements to include.

Guidelines:

1. Include accurate daily calorie amount
2. Show protein, fat, and carb amounts
3. Specify when to eat each meal
4. Use only foods that fit restrictions
5. List all portion sizes in grams
6. Keep budget-friendly if mentioned

When to Use Each Approach

Here's a practical guide for when to use each type of specificity:

Always Use Output Guidelines

You should include quality guidelines in almost every prompt you write. They're your safety net for getting consistent, useful results.

Use Process Steps For Complex Problems

Add step-by-step instructions when you're dealing with:

- Troubleshooting complex problems
- Decision-making scenarios
- Critical thinking tasks
- Any situation where you want Claude to consider multiple angles

When to Provide “Steps”

Try listing steps for the model to follow with these kinds of prompts:

- Troubleshooting hard problems
- Decision making
- Critical thinking
- Anytime you want to force Claude to consider a “wider” view

Write a one page decision report to troubleshoot why a sales team's numbers have dropped 30% last quarter.

Follow these steps:

1. Compare current vs previous market metrics
2. Identify relevant industry changes
3. Analyze individual team member performance
4. Consider recent organizational changes
5. Review customer feedback

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For instance, if you're asking Claude to analyze why a sales team's performance dropped, you'd want to guide it through examining market metrics, industry changes, individual performance, organizational changes, and customer feedback - rather than letting it focus on just one potential cause.

Combining Both Approaches

In professional prompting, you'll often see both techniques used together. You might have guidelines that control the format and content of your output, plus steps that ensure Claude thinks through the problem thoroughly before responding.

This combination gives you both consistency in your results and confidence that Claude has considered all the important factors in reaching its conclusion.